



From tragedy to triumph

Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay was born to Ananthaya Dhareshwar and Girjabai in Mangalore (now Mengaluru). Although she grew up in a liberal, reformist atmosphere, young Kamaladevi had to weather several tragedies. Her father died unexpectedly, leaving the family in financial disarray, two of her sisters were trapped in abusive marriages and died young, and she herself lost her husband within a year of being married. These experiences brought home to her the importance of women's rights and a gender-just society. Meeting social reformers and political activists like Annie Besant, Pandita Ramabai, Gopal Krishna Gokhale and MK Gandhi also inspired her to involve herself in the freedom movement.

"I WISH TO PROVE TO THE WORLD THAT A WOMAN CAN FIGHT AND FIGHT WELL IN SPITE OF EVERYTHING."